

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN DJIBOUTI

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Djibouti is a tiny, strategically pivotal, desperately water-scarce nation whose development is dominated by ports, foreign bases, and debt — and whose gravest environmental question is simply whether its people, above all its rural herders, will have water to live. It has no rivers that run year-round and receives almost no rain; it has among the very least fresh water per person of any nation on earth, far below even the recognised threshold of absolute scarcity; its groundwater is being drawn down faster than it can refill and is turning salty; and its recurring droughts, worsening with the climate, fall hardest on the pastoralist communities of the arid interior, where fewer than half the people have safe water while the capital has far more. Into the teeth of this scarcity the nation builds desalination plants, pipes water in from a neighbour, and pursues ports, free zones, and heavy industry along its coasts and salt flats. There is no single landmark victory to point to, the political space is limited, and the geopolitics of chokepoints and bases lies beyond the nation's control. But water is Djibouti's binding constraint, and that gives real ground.

Those who would defend Djibouti's water and land work with real, if constrained, tools — worked carefully and largely through the funders and the technical. The strongest is the **water-sustainability argument**: in one of the world's most water-scarce nations, a project that depletes or salts the water is self-defeating, and showing so is an argument aligned with the nation's own survival, not against it. The **rural herders' fair claim** — to the water and investment they are denied while the capital has far more — is a powerful equity argument. The **natural heritage** — the salt lakes, forests, and coasts — is a unique inheritance worth more whole than industrialised. And the distinctive lever: the **international funders who finance Djibouti's development** carry safeguards, environmental-assessment requirements, and accountability mechanisms that a case can invoke, because donor-financed projects must meet the funders' rules. The nation's own stated **sustainability goals** can be held to alongside them. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Djibouti genuinely lacks water and genuinely needs development, with few options, and is poor and heavily indebted, so its choices are constrained. Its environment is shaped by a geopolitics of chokepoints and bases beyond its control. It is an authoritarian state with real limits on dissent and criticism, and powerful foreign partners, so the work must run through the international, funder, and technical channels, never open confrontation — protecting the rural and marginalised communities and any advocate whose position could be jeopardised. And there is no single victory to point to. So the honest prize is a project made sustainable and equitable, the water protected, the rural claim advanced, and the funders' safeguards enforced — not an open defeat of a needed development. Above all, frame everything around the water's sustainability, the nation's own goals, and the funders' rules, and protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot deny a water-scarce nation its development, nor safely mount open confrontation in an authoritarian state with powerful foreign partners. What you can do is make the case the nation's own survival demands: show that a project depleting or salting the water is self-defeating, advance the rural herders' fair claim, defend the unique heritage, and above all invoke the safeguards and rules the international funders require of every project they finance — all carefully, framed around sustainability and the funders' rules, and protecting the people.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Djibouti is a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed, authoritarian setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline. The nation's need for water and development is genuine, its choices constrained by debt and geopolitics, and its space for dissent limited. This is not a fight you win by denial or confrontation. It is a careful effort worked through the funders, the technical bodies, and the water's own logic, whose realistic prize is a project made sustainable and equitable and the funders' safeguards enforced — not an open stop. Frame everything around sustainability and the funders' rules, and protect the rural and marginalised communities.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with an authoritarian state whose development is financed by foreign funders and shaped by foreign bases. But the decisions a careful effort can reach run through the funders and the technical: the **international funders and their safeguards and assessment requirements**, the **technical and regional water bodies**, the **nation's own stated sustainability goals**, and the **water's binding logic** itself. Map who finances and decides a project, and where the funders' rules and the water's limits bite, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A port, plant, or industrial project advances by state decision and foreign finance, and — where a funder is involved — must meet that funder's environmental and social safeguards and assessment. That safeguard process is the point of entry: a documented case can invoke the funders' rules, show the harm to the scarce water, and advance the rural claim. The strongest entry point is the one that touches the nation's own survival: the water's sustainability.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the water: what a project depletes, salts, or diverts, and whether that is sustainable in the world's most water-scarce nation. Follow the finance: which international funders back the project, and what safeguards, assessments, and accountability mechanisms they require. Follow the equity: whether the rural herders are denied the water and investment the capital receives. The leverage lies in the water's sustainability, the funders' safeguards, and the rural claim.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is limited in an authoritarian state, but the international funders' safeguard and accountability mechanisms, the technical and regional water bodies, and the nation's own stated sustainability goals are the channels a careful case engages — holding each to the funders' rules, the water's limits, and the fair claim of the rural people.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Djiboutian effort easily halts a needed, foreign-financed project, and honesty requires saying so — the nation is poor, indebted, and constrained. But the water's logic, the funders' safeguards, and the rural claim are real. The single most decisive move is **invoking the funders' safeguards and the water's sustainability together**, because donor-financed projects must meet the funders' rules, and because in the world's most water-scarce nation a project that harms the water is self-defeating on the nation's own terms.

The funders' leverage is the distinctive tool; the water-sustainability argument the sharpest; the rural claim the strongest equity ground. The realistic prize is a project made sustainable and equitable and the safeguards enforced — pursued carefully and safely.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the water depleted or salted, the rural people denied, the heritage industrialised. **Is it sustainable?** — whether the project harms the scarce water on which the nation depends. **Who finances it?** — which funders back it, and what safeguards they require. **Who is denied?** — whether the rural herders lose the water and investment the capital receives. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by working through the funders and technical channels and protecting the rural and marginalised. Pick the harm where the funders' safeguards and the water's logic offer the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, framed around sustainability. **Layer one: the harm** — the water depleted or salted, the rural people denied, the heritage at risk, documented technically. **Layer two: the rule and the logic** — the funders' safeguards and assessment the project must meet, the nation's own sustainability goals, and the self-defeating harm to the scarce water. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which funder, technical body, or safeguard mechanism to reach, and the discipline of framing everything around sustainability and the funders' rules, protecting the rural and marginalised. A case built on the water's sustainability and the funders' own safeguards is one the funders and the technical bodies must answer.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **water record**: the depletion, salination, and diversion data, the scarcity figures, the harm to the groundwater. Gather the **finance record**: the funders behind the project, their safeguards, assessment requirements, and accountability mechanisms. Gather the **equity record**: the rural herders' denial of water and investment against the capital's share. Gather the **heritage record**: the salt lakes, forests, and coasts at risk. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work runs through the funders and technical channels, and protects the rural and marginalised and any advocate.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE TECHNICAL, RURAL & INTERNATIONAL COALITION

Build the coalition carefully and only where it is safe: the **rural and pastoralist communities**, whose fair claim to water is the equity ground, protected always; the **technical and water experts** who hold the sustainability case; the **international funders and their safeguard mechanisms**, who carry the leverage; and the **regional and international water and development partners**. Frame the effort around the water's sustainability, the nation's own goals, and the funders' rules, never around challenging authority; and protect the rural, coastal, and marginalised communities and any advocate whose position could be jeopardised.

STEP 4: WATER, EQUITY & FUNDER LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM CAREFULLY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained, the nation needs development, and the work must be careful and funder-channelled.

The Water-Sustainability Argument

In one of the world's most water-scarce nations, **a project that depletes or salts the water is self-defeating** — and showing so, technically and clearly, is an argument aligned with the nation's own survival. This is the strongest lever: press the harm to the scarce water above all.

The Rural Claim and the Heritage

The **rural herders' fair claim** — to the water and investment denied them while the capital has far more — is a powerful equity argument, and the **salt lakes, forests, and coasts** are a unique heritage worth more whole. Advance both, on the nation's own terms of fairness and worth.

The Donor Leverage

The distinctive lever is the **international funders who finance Djibouti's development**: their safeguards, environmental and social assessments, and accountability mechanisms must be met by every project they back, and a documented case can invoke them. Pursued together — the water's sustainability, the rural claim and heritage, and the funders' leverage — these levers make a project more sustainable and equitable, while protecting the people.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always framed around sustainability. **For the funders**: here is a project that fails your safeguards, harms the scarce water, and denies the rural people — against your own rules. **For the technical bodies**: here is the sustainability case on a water-scarce nation's binding constraint. **For the nation's own goals**: here is a project at odds with the sustainability you aspire to. **For the equity claim**: here is the rural water and investment denied while the capital has more. **The golden rule**: frame everything around the water's sustainability, the nation's own goals, and the funders' rules, never around challenging authority, and protect the rural and marginalised.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in an authoritarian state with powerful partners. Frame any attention around **the water and the rural people**: the world's most water-scarce nation, and whether its herders will have water to live — never around challenging the government. Carry it through the funder, technical, and international development channels more than through open confrontation. A few cautions govern everything: keep it framed around sustainability and the funders' rules; never frame it as a challenge to authority; protect the rural and marginalised and any advocate; and let the water's logic and the funders' safeguards carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message framed around sustainability and the funders' rules, and protective of the rural and marginalised.

8A — To an international funder: set out the harm to the scarce water and the rural people, and ask how the project meets the funder's safeguards.

8B — To a funder's accountability mechanism: document the safeguard failure and request review.

8C — To a technical or water body: present the sustainability case on the water-scarce nation's binding constraint.

8D — On the rural claim: document the water and investment denied to the herders while the capital has more, and press the equity case.

8E — On the heritage: flag the salt lakes, forests, or coasts at risk and ask for protection.

8F — On the nation's own goals: recall the sustainability the nation aspires to and show where the project departs from it.

8G — To a regional or development partner: describe the water and equity stakes and request engagement.

8H — To the international public: summarise the water and the rural claim — framed around sustainability — and ask for attention, without exposing anyone.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the harm to the scarce water and the funders behind the project; write the one-page sustainability-and-safeguards case; identify the funder or accountability mechanism to reach. **The fastest-moving levers:** the funders' safeguards, the water-sustainability argument, and the rural claim.

Emergency coalition-building: reach the funders' safeguard channels and the technical water experts first — safely and framed around sustainability. Throughout, protect the rural and marginalised.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by an authoritarian state, foreign finance and bases, debt, and geopolitics beyond the nation's control. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not denial, but a project made sustainable and equitable and the safeguards enforced. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily dismiss: the funders' own safeguards, the water's binding logic, the rural equity claim. And accept the honest limits — the nation needs development, the space is constrained, and no single victory exists — while still making the project more sustainable and protecting the people.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — projects steered to insiders or foreign partners, water directed to the powerful while the rural go without, safeguards waved through. Where capture appears, respond only through the **funder and international channels:** the safeguards, the accountability mechanisms, the technical bodies, the documented record. Never through open confrontation. **On safety and care:** this note matters throughout. Djibouti is an authoritarian state with real limits on dissent and powerful foreign partners. Favour the funders' channels, the technical and regional bodies, and careful documentation over open confrontation; protect individuals, especially the rural, coastal, and marginalised communities and any

advocate whose position could be jeopardised; frame the work around the water's sustainability, the nation's own goals, and the funders' rules, never around challenging authority; and handle the government and the geopolitics factually. Care is the first rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, framed around sustainability and only where safe. The documented harm feeds the water-sustainability argument, the funders' safeguard challenge, and the rural claim at once; the technical, rural, and international coalition organises carefully alongside; the media carries the water frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm to the water and the funders behind the project; **months two to six**, press the funders' safeguards, the sustainability case, and the rural claim; **beyond**, secure the safeguards and the sustainable, equitable outcome. The core discipline: sustainability-framed, funder-driven, careful, and absolute in protecting the rural and marginalised.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Djibouti is a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed, authoritarian ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a needed development can simply be denied, or that the space is open, or that a single victory exists — none of that is true, and the nation genuinely lacks water and options. What it claims is narrower and real: that in the world's most water-scarce nation, a project that depletes or salts the water is self-defeating on the nation's own terms; that the rural herders have a fair claim to the water and investment they are denied; that the salt lakes, forests, and coasts are a unique heritage; and that, above all, the international funders who finance Djibouti's development carry safeguards and rules a case can invoke. The levers are constrained, the work careful and funder-channelled, and the prize is a project made sustainable and equitable and the safeguards enforced — not an open defeat of a needed development. But for a tiny, water-scarce, donor-financed state, that careful, sustainability-framed effort — worked through the funders' rules and the water's own logic, and protecting the rural and marginalised — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one.